



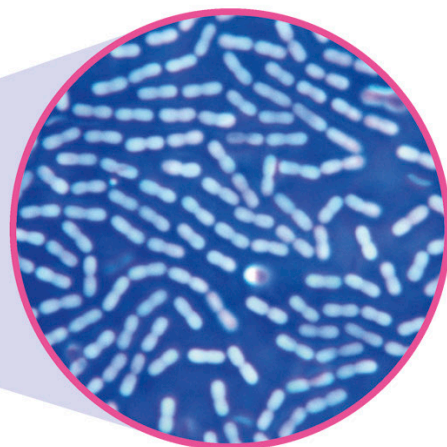
Teeny tiny WORLD

Most organisms on the planet are invisible to us, but if you were to look at a cubic inch of air, water, or soil with a microscope you would find it bursting with life. We call these tiny life forms microorganisms, or microbes. They include plants, animals, fungi, protists, and all bacteria.

Microscopes have become more and more powerful; now we can see up to a magnification of 500,000 times with a scanning electron microscope.

Microbes are like other living things—some make their own food and some have to eat other organisms. They live on their own or in colonies in every kind of environment: on land, in water, and in the air. Some, called archaeobacteria, survive in the most hostile places on the planet—hot springs, acid pools, and deep in the ground—places that would be deadly to other life forms.

BACTERIA



Now you see them...

Even though they could not be seen, for centuries people believed that microorganisms existed and that they could be the cause of disease. It was not until the invention of the microscope in the 17th century that it became obvious just how many microorganisms there were. A Dutch scientist, Anton van Leeuwenhoek, known as the “Father of Microbiology,” was the first to observe what he called “animalcules.”

I’ve just spotted an *animalcule*!

ANTON VAN LEEUWENHOEK

